district the message be engraved on rocks as also on stone pillars wherever these had been erected. By ensuring that his voice was cast in stone, Ashoka made sure that this part of his life was set out as exemplary in exactly the way that he wanted.

Presenting his life in this way was central to Ashoka's missionary intent. This was now life-history as model and prototype, the sole example for the populace to follow. The new hegemonic enterprise shines through his first edict as much as in those that follow. What is less evident but appears in retrospect implicit is that he was interpreting his own life and behaviour in a way that would have reminded knowledgeable observers of crucial incidents within an earlier historical life. As one ponders over the constituent elements of this edict, one cannot escape the strong feeling that there is in the emperor's autobiographical vignette some echo of Siddhartha Gautama, the man who became the Buddha in the sixth century BCE.[26] Siddhartha's decision to renounce worldly life, his later biographers underlined, was related to a personal trauma. Ashoka does not mention the Kalinga war and his post-war crisis in his first edict, but we cannot escape reading even this pithy tablet in the light of one of the most famous nuggets of ancient history, namely the transformative impact of the Kalinga war on the conqueror. Again, while the Buddha moved from being the head of his household to a wandering life in search of truth, the king's traditional calling as head of his 'household', the state, changes to a moral mission. Like the wandering Buddha, who taught as he travelled, the converted Buddhist king embarks on his mission by touring his empire. His inclusive moral path is patently the Buddha's. Above all, just as the Buddha never failed to reveal personal experience as the basis of his teachings, Ashoka's life and his new kingly calling are inextricably combined. The Buddha acquired disciples; Ashoka's disciples were in a sense his entire administrative apparatus. Was Ashoka indeed framing his life and message to evoke some elements of the Buddha? This possibility, apparent enough to